

COURSE & SYLLABUS / FALL SEMESTER

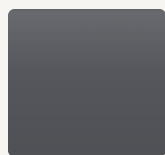
ART LAB: FOUNDATIONS

SEEING, MAKING & MEANING

A 16-week, material-driven studio course. Students learn to see carefully, make their own paint, cast and gild, print with sunlight, and create work that carries an idea.

THE SEMESTER IN SIXTEEN PIGMENTS

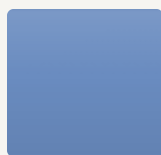
One pigment for every week of the course



01
GRAPHITE



02
BONE BLACK



03
TWILIGHT BLUE



04
EGG YOLK



05
YELLOW OCHRE



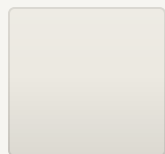
06
BURNT SIENNA



07
MADDER RED



08
RAW UMBER



09
PLASTER WHITE



10
GREEN EARTH



11
GOLD LEAF



12
PRUSSIAN BLUE



13
INDIGO



14
CAPUT
MORTUUM



15
VIRIDIAN



16
ULTRAMARINE

**A STUDIO
COURSE,
TAUGHT LIVE
ONLINE**

WEEKLY CLASS

About one hour, live, with a short demo video before each session

BETWEEN CLASSES

Project work and 5–10 minute sketchbook practice most days

FOR

High school students; motivated middle schoolers welcome

WELCOME

AN ART CLASS THAT BEGINS WITH SEEING

Students don't just use materials. They learn to understand them: how they are made, how they behave, where they come from, and how artists have used them to create meaning.

ABOUT THE COURSE

Art Lab: Foundations is a studio course for students who want to go further than making a nice picture. Over sixteen weeks they learn to observe carefully, understand how art materials are made and why they behave the way they do, and use that knowledge to make work that says something.

It is hands-on in a way online classes rarely are. Students mix pigment into egg yolk the way Renaissance painters did, paint with milk-based casein like Jacob Lawrence, cast plaster in molds they design, lay gold leaf and print images with sunlight. Each technique arrives with the artists and history behind it, so students leave with stronger skills and a deeper appreciation for the art they see for the rest of their lives.

YOUR STUDENT WILL

-  Draw from observation with real structure, light and form
-  Build layered collage and mixed-media compositions
-  Lay gold leaf and explore how light behaves on a surface
-  Plan, test, finish and present a month-long final project
-  Mix color by hand and make egg tempera and casein paint
-  Design a mold, cast plaster, then carve and finish it
-  Make prints by transfer, monoprint and cyanotype
-  Look at art with a trained eye, and talk about it with confidence

AT A GLANCE

LENGTH	16 weeks, fall semester	LIVE CLASS	About one hour each week, online
BEFORE CLASS	Short demo video and setup checklist	SKETCHBOOK	5–10 minutes, 4–6 days a week
BETWEEN CLASSES	Project work, drying and curing time	EXPERIENCE	None needed; curiosity matters most

PROCESS OVER PERFECTION. STUDIES, FAILED TESTS AND REVISIONS ARE PART OF THE COURSE, NOT EVIDENCE THAT SOMETHING WENT WRONG.

WHAT STUDENTS GAIN

SKILL AND JUDGMENT, BUILT TOGETHER

Students learn a repeatable way to approach unfamiliar visual problems, rather than memorizing one way to draw or paint.

STUDIO SKILLS

Observation, proportion, form, value, composition, color and craftsmanship.

MATERIAL + PROCESS

Pigment, binder, paper, surface, texture, casting, reflection, printing and layering.

MEANING + CONTEXT

Art history, symbolism, culture, faith, beauty, brokenness, imagination and interpretation.

THE CORE PROGRESSION

01	02	03	04	05	06	07
SEE	BUILD	EXPERIMENT	LAYER	TRANSFORM	REFINE	COMMUNICATE

OBSERVATION

Break complex subjects into large shapes and simple three-dimensional forms before adding detail.

DRAWING

Use proportion, overlap, perspective, value, edge, texture and cast shadow to create believable form.

COLOR

Mix primaries intentionally; understand warm and cool, complements, limited palettes and value shifts.

PAINT MAKING

Understand paint as pigment plus binder by making and comparing egg tempera and casein.

MIXED MEDIA

Combine drawing, paint, collage, found material and print as one language, not separate subjects.

MATERIAL THINKING

Build, cast, carve, sand, stain and gild, considering what the physical material contributes.

ART HISTORY + MEANING

Use historical and contemporary art to discuss culture, faith, beauty, symbolism and memory.

STUDIO PRACTICE

Plan, test, revise, document, critique and finish a sustained project over several weeks.

QUESTIONS WE RETURN TO

What changes when we slow down and truly observe before drawing?

How do form, value, color, texture and composition guide what a viewer notices?

What is paint actually made of, and how does a binder change the behavior of pigment?

How can flat images become layered surfaces, reliefs and physical objects?

How have artists used beauty, disruption, symbolism, light and material to communicate belief or meaning?

How does an artist move from an assigned technique toward intentional personal choices?

HOW A WEEK WORKS

AN ONLINE STUDIO THAT FEELS LIKE A STUDIO

Demonstrations move to short videos before class, so the live hour is spent looking together and making, with the instructor troubleshooting in real time.

BEFORE CLASS

Watch a 6–8 minute demo video filmed from overhead.

Set out the week's materials using the setup checklist, so class time goes to making.

LIVE CLASS, ~60 MIN

LOOK

LEARN

MAKE

CLOSE

5–10 min Slow looking at one artwork: what do you see, think, wonder?

10–15 min Technique, material science, artists and history.

25–35 min Studio time with live help and feedback.

5 min What happens next, and what to notice while working.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Continue the project; allow drying and curing time.

Sketchbook practice most days.

Post a photo to the class gallery with one “I notice...” comment on a classmate’s work.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

5–10 MIN

4–6 days a week, every week of the course

Short, frequent drawing keeps the observation skills from the first weeks growing all semester, even in weeks spent with paint and plaster. Each week has its own prompt, tied to what the class is learning.

The sketchbook also holds thumbnails, color recipes, pigment tests, material notes and mistakes worth remembering. It can be messy. It is evidence of thinking.

EXAMPLE PROMPT, WEEK 11

Draw a shiny object, like a spoon, and map its reflections as shapes.

THE BOOKEND DRAWING

In Week 1 students draw an ordinary object. Before the final class they draw it again with the same setup. Side by side, the two drawings show a semester of growth more clearly than any grade.



WEEK 01



WEEK 16

CRITIQUE, ONLINE

Each week three students are spotlighted live, and everyone shares in the class gallery. We begin with observation before interpretation, and ask questions before suggesting fixes. The aim is specific, useful feedback, never competition.

COURSE ARC

FOUR PHASES, ONE SEMESTER

From careful seeing, to handmade color, to physical material, to a month of sustained personal work. Each phase includes one assignment that sends students out to look at art in the world.

Phase I



SEEING + INTERPRETATION

3 WEEKS Weeks 1–3

Drawing foundations of structure, value and observation lead into Surrealism. Students use technical skill to make impossible images feel believable, then talk about beauty, brokenness and truth.

Looking outside class: Light hunt. Photograph three strong cast shadows at home and bring the best one to class.

Phase II



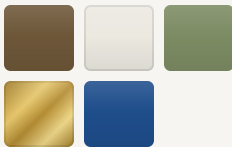
COLOR, HANDMADE PAINT + LAYER

4 WEEKS Weeks 4–7

Color theory becomes physical. Students make egg tempera and casein from pigment and binder, then layer drawing, paint, collage and found material into new compositions.

Looking outside class: Zoom in. Study one tempera painting up close in a museum or on Google Arts & Culture, and sketch a single detail.

Phase III



SURFACE, FORM + MATERIAL

5 WEEKS Weeks 8–12

Flat images become objects. Students build relief, cast and carve plaster, gild a surface and run a printmaking lab where chance becomes part of the image.

Looking outside class: Relief in the wild. Find carved or cast relief in your town, on a doorway, building, monument or grave marker, and photograph it in low, raking light.

Phase IV



SYNTHESIS + FINAL PROJECT

4 WEEKS Weeks 13–16

A full month to propose, test, build and refine one substantial artwork, choosing materials because they support an idea, not because they appeared in class.

Looking outside class: See one show. Visit a museum, gallery or student exhibition in person before the final critique.

AT A GLANCE

SIXTEEN WEEKS

PHASE I SEEING + INTERPRETATION

Week 01		Big shapes first	DRAWING FOUNDATIONS I	Seeing, simplifying and constructing form
Week 02		Light, value + form	DRAWING FOUNDATIONS II	Value, light, texture and believable volume
Week 03		Beauty, brokenness + truth	SURREALISM + MEANING	The impossible scene, made believable

PHASE II COLOR, HANDMADE PAINT + LAYER

Week 04		Mixing what you see	COLOR + EGG TEMPERA	Mix color by hand; make and use egg tempera
Week 05		Paint is made	PIGMENT + CASEIN	Pigment + binder: make casein paint
Week 06		Image + layer	MIXED MEDIA I	Alter, combine, obscure, reveal
Week 07		Composition + transformation	MIXED MEDIA II	Collage, scale, transparency, focal point

PHASE III SURFACE, FORM + MATERIAL

Week 08		When the surface becomes an object	TEXTURE + RELIEF	From flat image to tactile surface
Week 09		Design in reverse	CASTING I	Design a mold, mix and cast
Week 10		Carve, finish + combine	CASTING II	Demold, carve, finish and combine
Week 11		Gilding and reflection	SURFACE + LIGHT	Gold leaf, reflective and translucent surface
Week 12		Chance and control	PRINT + PROCESS LAB	Printmaking: transfer, monoprint, cyanotype

PHASE IV SYNTHESIS + FINAL PROJECT

Week 13		Concept + material tests	FINAL I	Proposal, thumbnails, material tests
Week 14		Build the major structure	FINAL II	Establish structure and major relationships
Week 15		Develop, edit + refine	FINAL III	Surface, color, editing, critique
Week 16		Finish + present	FINAL IV	Resolve, photograph, present and reflect

TOTAL	16 weeks	16 live sessions of about one hour, plus sketchbook practice and project work between classes
-------	----------	---

01

Week 01

DRAWING FOUNDATIONS I

PHASE I

BIG SHAPES FIRST

Complex subjects become manageable once you find the large shapes and simple forms underneath them.

GRAPHITE

LOOK + DISCUSS

Albrecht Dürer's nature studies and Leonardo's notebooks: drawing as a way of paying attention. We compare symbolic drawing (what we think an object looks like) with observation (what is actually there).

IN CLASS

Warm-ups with sphere, box, cylinder and cone, plus ellipses. Then shoes, buildings, trees or household objects built from large shapes before any detail.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Short observational sketches following one rule: large shape → structure → smaller forms → details.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4-6 times a week, 5-10 minutes

One everyday object a day (a cup, a shoe, a lamp), blocked in with big shapes before any detail.

ON THE TABLE Pencils HB-6B, eraser, sketchbook, a few household objects.

STRETCH Draw one complex object, like a bicycle or chair, using only construction lines.

02

Week 02

DRAWING FOUNDATIONS II

PHASE I

LIGHT, VALUE + FORM

Value turns a flat shape into believable volume.

BONE BLACK

LOOK + DISCUSS

Caravaggio, Rembrandt and Georges de La Tour, who used light to carry meaning as well as to describe.

IN CLASS

Light, middle and dark; form shadow and cast shadow; block shading, cross-hatching, scumbling and linear marks, all applied to one object under a single light.

BETWEEN CLASSES

A value study and one observational drawing with a consistent light source.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4-6 times a week, 5-10 minutes

Find one object in single-source light each day (a lamp, a window) and draw it in three values.

ON THE TABLE Pencils, blending stump, desk lamp, a white object such as an egg or mug.

STRETCH A full value drawing in charcoal and white chalk on toned paper.

03

Week 03

SURREALISM + MEANING

PHASE I

BEAUTY, BROKENNESS + TRUTH

Technical skill can serve imagination. A strange image grows stronger when every object in it feels convincing.

LOOK + DISCUSS

Dalí, Magritte, Remedios Varo and Leonora Carrington. Can art show what is strange, broken or unsettling and still reveal something beautiful or true? Surrealism can be a visual language without being a worldview.

IN CLASS

A full-page impossible scene built from believable form, scale, overlap, perspective and shadow. We discuss choices while students work.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Develop and finish the Surrealist drawing, ready to show at the start of Week 4.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

One “what if” a day: an ordinary object at an impossible scale, in an impossible material or place.

ON THE TABLE Drawing kit and reference photos.

STRETCH Hide a visual rhyme: two unrelated objects that share one shape.

04

Week 04

COLOR + EGG TEMPERA

PHASE II

MIXING WHAT YOU SEE

Color theory becomes meaningful when you physically mix color instead of only naming it on a wheel.

LOOK + DISCUSS

The glowing panels of Duccio and Fra Angelico, and Andrew Wyeth's 20th-century tempera. Why a slow, layered paint produces such luminous color.

IN CLASS

Primaries, secondaries, complements, warm and cool, value. Students mix pigment into egg-yolk binder and build their own color-mixing chart.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Finish the chart or a small tempera study using only colors you mixed. Optional: add selective color to the Surrealist drawing.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Each day, note five colors you actually see (not their “name” color) and write how you would mix one.

ON THE TABLE Eggs, pigment pastes, palette, small brushes, watercolor paper or panel.

STRETCH Build form with hatched tempera strokes, the way medieval painters did.

05

Week 05

PIGMENT + CASEIN

PHASE II

PAINT IS MADE

Paint is pigment carried by a binder. Change the binder and you change the paint.

YELLOW OCHRE

LOOK + DISCUSS

Jacob Lawrence painted his Migration Series in casein tempera. We also look at milk paints in folk and decorative painting, and ask why an artist would choose a matte surface over a luminous one.

IN CLASS

A demonstration of how milk protein becomes a binder, and safe pigment handling. Students combine pigment paste with prepared casein binder in small batches, then make a mixing chart and a compact painted study.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Finish the casein study. Note which colors covered well, which felt transparent, and how casein differed from tempera.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Plan one scene from your day as flat shapes and a few colors, the way Lawrence composed.

ON THE TABLE Casein binder, pigment pastes, illustration board or cardboard, brushes.

STRETCH Use only three pigments plus white. How many colors can you mix?

06

Week 06

MIXED MEDIA I

PHASE II

IMAGE + LAYER

Adding material should change the image, not simply decorate it.

BURNT SIENNA

LOOK + DISCUSS

Kurt Schwitters, Joseph Cornell and Betye Saar, who brought ordinary materials into art. Can a material carry memory before it is altered?

IN CLASS

Combine a drawing or image with casein, collage paper, text, tracing paper, cardboard, thread, fabric or foil. Practice covering, revealing, tearing, cutting, sanding and redrawing.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Continue the layered piece, then remove at least one element that isn't helping. Editing is part of making.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Tape in one found scrap a day (a ticket, a label, a leaf) and draw into or around it.

ON THE TABLE Glue, scissors, collage papers, found materials, casein paints.

STRETCH Build a layer you later sand back to reveal what lies beneath.

07

Week 07

MIXED MEDIA II

PHASE II

COMPOSITION + TRANSFORMATION

A mixed-media work needs the same compositional discipline as a drawing.

MADDER RED

LOOK + DISCUSS

Hannah Höch's photomontages and Romare Bearden's collages: fragments assembled into a new visual world. How context changes meaning.

IN CLASS

A new or expanded composition of found imagery, hand drawing and painted passages, focusing on scale change, overlap, negative space, focal point, transparency and edge.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Resolve the composition. Photograph it straight-on and write one note: where does the eye go first, and why?

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4-6 times a week, 5-10 minutes

Three tiny thumbnails a day of the same subject, moving the focal point each time.

ON THE TABLE Printed images, tracing paper, glue, paints.

STRETCH Rebuild the same pieces into a second version with a new focal point.

08

Week 08

TEXTURE + RELIEF

PHASE III

WHEN THE SURFACE BECOMES AN OBJECT

The step from 2D to 3D can begin with only a few millimeters of depth.

RAW UMBER

LOOK + DISCUSS

Ghiberti's Gates of Paradise and Louise Nevelson's wall assemblages; relief in doors, architecture and sacred spaces. How real light changes a surface through the day.

IN CLASS

A shallow relief from cardboard, string, fabric, sand and modeling paste: raised and recessed areas, rough and smooth passages, edges that cast real shadows. Paint or stain only after the structure works.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Finish the relief and photograph a close-up in raking light. Collect small textures and objects to press into clay next week.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4-6 times a week, 5-10 minutes

Texture hunt: bark, brick, rope, fabric, any surface you could build.

ON THE TABLE Cardboard, glue, string, modeling paste, plasticine.

STRETCH Design with shadow: make the cast shadows part of the composition.

09

Week 09

CASTING I

PHASE III

DESIGN IN REVERSE

Casting reverses normal making: you design the empty space first and reveal the object later.

PLASTER WHITE

LOOK + DISCUSS

Roman concrete and the Pantheon, and Rachel Whiteread, who casts the empty space inside and around things. Why stone-like materials suggest permanence and memory.

IN CLASS

Safety briefing first. Press a design into oil-based clay inside a small container: incised lines, pressed textures, carved hollows. Mix casting plaster and pour. A cement mix is available to older students with instructor approval.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Let the cast set undisturbed. Sketch two finishing ideas for Week 10.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Draw things in reverse: a footprint, the inside of a cup, a keyhole, a mold.

ON THE TABLE Plasticine, small container, pre-portioned plaster, mixing cup, gloves, goggles.

STRETCH Add integral pigment or fine aggregate to a test pour and compare.

10

Week 10

CASTING II

PHASE III

CARVE, FINISH + COMBINE

A cast object is a beginning. Surface and context decide what it becomes.

GREEN EARTH

LOOK + DISCUSS

Kintsugi, the Japanese art of mending broken pottery with gold, alongside ancient fragments and patina. Why artists keep cracks and wear instead of hiding them.

IN CLASS

Demold. Sand, carve, incise and refine edges; apply a pigment wash or stain. Begin joining the cast piece with wood, wire, paper, textile or a painted panel.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Complete the integrated object. Photograph the whole piece and one detail of its surface.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Draw something cracked, worn or mended.

ON THE TABLE Carving tools, sandpaper, pigment wash, found materials.

STRETCH Break a test cast on purpose and design its repair.

11



GOLD LEAF

Week 11

SURFACE + LIGHT

PHASE III

GILDING AND REFLECTION

Light can act like a material. A reflective surface changes as the viewer moves.

LOOK + DISCUSS

Byzantine and Ethiopian icons, illuminated manuscripts and Klimt, then kintsugi again. Gold used for luxury versus gold as a symbol: a field of light rather than a place.

IN CLASS

Simplified gilding with water-based size and imitation leaf, used as one intentional focal point, perhaps on the cast piece. Compare matte, glossy, translucent and metallic passages.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Finish the surface study and photograph it from two angles so the change in light is visible.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Draw a shiny object (a spoon, a doorknob, a glass) and map its reflections as shapes.

ON THE TABLE Gilding size, imitation leaf, soft brush, cast piece or panel.

STRETCH Sgraffito: paint over gold, then scratch back through to it.

12



PRUSSIAN BLUE

Week 12

PRINT + PROCESS LAB

PHASE III

CHANCE AND CONTROL

Not every decision has to be predicted. Artists can design a process, then respond to what happens.

LOOK + DISCUSS

Anna Atkins's cyanotypes, Degas's monotypes, Robert Rauschenberg's transfer drawings and Max Ernst's frottage, a Surrealist chance method that links back to Week 3.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Add one intentional intervention to the best print: drawing, cut, paint, text, stitch, gilding or collage. Bring it to Week 13 as a possible final-project test.

CHOOSE ONE PROCESS

Several fast experiments with one printmaking process, then select and alter the strongest rather than accepting the first result.

ACRYLIC TRANSFER

Move a laser-printed or photocopied image onto paper, panel or plaster with acrylic gel medium, then rub the paper away. Inkjet prints tend to smear.

MONOPRINT

Roll paint onto a gel plate, draw, mask and layer, and pull one-of-a-kind prints.

CYANOTYPE

Sun printing on pre-coated paper. A UV lamp helps on cloudy November days.

SUMINAGASHI

Floating-ink marbling: ink rings on water, lifted onto paper.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Start each page with a chance mark (a rubbing, a blot, a drip) and turn it into something.

ON THE TABLE Gel medium, brayer, gel plate, sun-print paper, laser-printed images.

STRETCH Combine two processes: a transfer printed over a cyanotype.

13

Week 13

FINAL I

PHASE IV

CONCEPT + MATERIAL TESTS

Strong work starts with a question or intention, not a shopping list of techniques.

INDIGO

LOOK + DISCUSS

Artists who combine media because the material supports the idea, such as Joseph Cornell's boxes and Anselm Kiefer's paintings built with straw, lead and ash. Symbolism without forcing one fixed meaning.

IN CLASS

Develop 2–3 concepts in thumbnails and name the main visual problem. Choose at least two material families from the semester and make small tests. The instructor approves scope and materials.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Show the chosen concept, a rough composition, a material plan and at least one test sample.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Daily idea pages: thumbnails, notes and reference sketches toward the final.

ON THE TABLE Anything from the semester's kits; the student's plan decides.

STRETCH A small, tightly connected series instead of a single piece.

14

Week 14

FINAL II

PHASE IV

BUILD THE MAJOR STRUCTURE

Establish the large relationships before polishing details.

CAPUT MORTUUM

LOOK + DISCUSS

Michelangelo's unfinished Prisoners, where rough stone and refined form sit side by side. Craftsmanship is not the same as perfection: what must be controlled, and what can stay raw?

IN CLASS

Studio week. Build the support, main composition, relief, cast part or major painted areas. Feedback focuses on scale, structure, hierarchy and whether the materials are helping the idea.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Reach a clear midpoint. Photograph the work and name the single biggest problem to solve next.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

A daily study of one detail from your final project's subject.

ON THE TABLE Final-project materials.

STRETCH Make a small side study to test a risky decision before trying it on the main piece.

15

Week 15

FINAL III

PHASE IV

DEVELOP, EDIT + REFINE

Refinement often means subtraction, repetition and better transitions, not adding more.

VIRIDIAN

LOOK + DISCUSS

Matisse photographed his Large Reclining Nude again and again as he simplified it over months. How do artists know when a work is resolved? Separating technical finishing from overworking.

IN CLASS

Continue surface, color, layering and assembly. Mid-project critique: what is strongest, what is competing, where does the eye go, what should go? Then revise.

BETWEEN CLASSES

Finish all major construction, leaving only finishing, photography and presentation. Make the bookend drawing before the final class.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

Draw your work in progress from a new angle each day and note one change.

ON THE TABLE Final-project materials.

STRETCH Write a 50-word museum-style label for your piece.

16

Week 16

FINAL IV

PHASE IV

FINISH + PRESENT

A work isn't finished until the artist can present it clearly and reflect on the decisions behind it.

ULTRAMARINE

LOOK + DISCUSS

Back to the semester theme of seeing, making and meaning, with each student's Week 1 and bookend drawings side by side. Museum wall labels as a model for explaining a work in a few clear sentences.

IN CLASS

Final adjustments, photography in good light, then an online showcase. Each student answers three questions: What were you trying to do? Why these materials? What changed along the way?

BETWEEN CLASSES

A final sketchbook reflection: one skill gained, one material to explore further, one question still open.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

4–6 times a week, 5–10 minutes

The bookend drawing, made before class: redraw your Week 1 subject with the same setup.

ON THE TABLE Finished work, a phone camera, good light.

STRETCH Assemble a one-page digital portfolio of your strongest work from the semester.

FINAL PROJECT / WEEKS 13–16

ONE MONTH OF SUSTAINED WORK

CREATE ONE SUBSTANTIAL ARTWORK, OR A SMALL, TIGHTLY CONNECTED BODY OF WORK, THAT COMBINES AT LEAST TWO MATERIAL OR PROCESS FAMILIES FROM THE SEMESTER.

The materials should support the idea, not simply appear because they were used in class.

REQUIREMENTS

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>01 A clear concept, question or visual intention that can be explained in ordinary language.</p> | <p>02 At least two material or process families from the semester, such as drawing + casein, collage + relief, cast plaster + gilding, or transfer + cyanotype.</p> |
| <p>03 Evidence of planning: thumbnails, reference images, a material test or a small prototype.</p> | <p>04 Meaningful development across Weeks 13–16. A one-night project doesn't meet the purpose of the assignment.</p> |
| <p>05 At least one revision after critique, and the ability to say what changed and why.</p> | <p>06 Clear documentation: a full image and a detail, photographed in even light against a simple background.</p> |
| <p>07 A short presentation describing intention, material choices, one problem solved and one unexpected discovery.</p> | <p>08 The bookend drawing, shown beside the student's Week 1 drawing.</p> |

INTENTION

The student can explain the visual problem or idea being pursued.

MATERIAL

Materials are handled with growing control and chosen for a reason.

DEVELOPMENT

The work changes through testing, critique, editing and revision.

PRESENTATION

The finished work is documented and discussed clearly, even if the artist would keep refining it.

AT THE FINAL SHOWCASE,
EVERY STUDENT ANSWERS

WHAT WERE YOU TRYING TO DO?

WHY THESE MATERIALS?

WHAT CHANGED ALONG THE WAY?

A technically perfect object with no intentional choices is not automatically stronger than a rougher work with real investigation. Craft matters, but the course values observation, experimentation, judgment and thoughtful revision together.

STUDIO PRACTICE

SKETCHBOOK, CRITIQUE AND ASSESSMENT

THE ART LAB SKETCHBOOK

One sketchbook for the whole semester, used 4–6 days a week for 5–10 minutes of drawing.

Weekly prompts connect daily drawing to the week's material, so observation keeps growing.

It also holds thumbnails, proportion notes, value studies, color recipes and pigment tests.

Material observations and mistakes worth remembering belong here too.

Final-project planning and the closing reflection live in its last pages.

Pages can be messy. They are evidence of thinking, not portfolio pieces.

HOW WE TALK ABOUT WORK

"I notice..."

"This makes me think..."

Begin with observation before interpretation.

Be specific about visual evidence: edge, value, scale, color, texture, focal point, rhythm, material.

Ask questions before prescribing a fix. The goal is to help the artist see choices, not redesign the work.

Students may disagree about meaning. Good critique separates what is visible from what is interpreted.

SUGGESTED EVALUATION, IF A GRADE IS NEEDED

35%

PROCESS + ENGAGEMENT

Participation, preparation, sketchbook practice, tests, willingness to revise.

25%

STUDIO SKILL + CRAFT

Growing control of drawing, color, surface and materials.

25%

PROJECT DEVELOPMENT

Composition, problem-solving, experimentation, follow-through.

15%

FINAL + REFLECTION

Sustained development, material intention, presentation.

MATERIALS & SUPPLIES

SUPPLIES IN THREE STAGES

Supplies are staged so families aren't buying everything at once. Specialty items are selected, and where possible pre-portioned, by the instructor. A separate Materials Guide lists every item week by week.

WEEKS 1-3

DRAWING

Graphite pencils HB-6B, charcoal, kneaded eraser, blending stump, toned paper and the Art Lab sketchbook.

WEEKS 4-7

PAINT LAB

Pigment pastes, prepared casein binder, palette, brushes, panels and illustration board, collage papers and glue.

WEEKS 8-16

SURFACE + FORM

Modeling paste, plasticine, casting plaster, carving tools, sandpaper, gilding size and imitation leaf, gel medium, gel plate, brayer, sun-print paper, gloves and goggles.

FROM HOME Eggs, a few household objects, cardboard and found materials, a desk lamp, a phone for photos, and old kitchen utensils that can be retired to art use.

HOME STUDIO SAFETY

Safety takes priority over technical complexity. Every material week includes a short safety briefing.

Approved pigments only. Non-toxic, instructor-approved pigments. No lead, cadmium, cobalt or chromium.

No airborne dust. Casting powder comes pre-portioned. Never blow or dry-sweep; clean up with a damp cloth.

Plaster gets warm as it sets. Never cast hands or any part of the body.

Never pour plaster down a drain. Let leftovers harden in the cup, then throw them away.

Acrylic sheet, not glass, for transparent drawing activities.

Art utensils stay art utensils. Spoons and cups used for paint or plaster never return to the kitchen.

Pigment arrives as paste. Pre-dispersed in water, so there is no dry pigment dust at home.

Gloves and eye protection for casting, gilding size and any material the instructor identifies as irritating.

Cement mixes are caustic when wet. Optional for older students only, with gloves, goggles and an adult nearby.

No chemistry mixing at home. Cyanotype uses pre-coated paper. No caustic activators are used.

Supervised tools. Cutting tools, heat tools and wire only with age-appropriate supervision.

A wipeable work surface and old clothes or an apron for every material week.

ART LAB: FOUNDATIONS

**LEARN TO SEE
CAREFULLY.
UNDERSTAND HOW
MATERIALS BEHAVE.
MAKE WORK THAT
CARRIES AN IDEA.**

